of Bengal. The meetings and publications of the Society provided an unusually fertile environment for innovative speculation, with scholars constantly exchanging notes on, for instance, how they had deciphered the Brahmi letters of various epigraphs from Samudragupta's Allahabad pillar inscription, to the Karle cave inscriptions. The Eureka moment came in 1837 when James Prinsep, a brilliant secretary of the Asiatic Society, building on earlier pools of epigraphic knowledge, very quickly uncovered the key to the extinct Mauryan Brahmi script. Prinsep unlocked Ashoka; his deciphering of the script made it possible to read the inscriptions. All this and more has been superbly told by Charles Allen.

Allen's focus on the *British* discovery of Ashoka does run a small danger, namely the possible inference that this ruler of ancient India was pretty much a forgotten entity until Raj antiquarians and archaeologists exhumed him. While Allen is right in showing us the concatenation of chance archaeological discoveries that gave us the Ashoka we see today, it is worth stressing that there was a continuous textual tradition, from Kashmir down to Sri Lanka, in which Ashoka featured.[37] Historical memory in relation to virtually all rulers and dynasties was far more the preserve of textual traditions than of folk knowledge and popular belief. So, before his epigraphs were deciphered, Ashoka was known mainly to a fairly restricted group of traditional scholars and pundits in India and Buddhist communities across Asia. The fact that Ashoka was not common knowledge is not to say that he was largely unknown, unless one qualifies this with the truism that but for Orientalist endeavours virtually all of ancient India, as we have it today, would have remained unknown. The extent to which the British and other explorers and scholars fleshed Ashoka out moved the emperor from his hiding place in sometimes esoteric Brahmanical knowledge and hagiographical Buddhist texts, making him a far more generally familiar figure.